THE BATTLE OF LAKE CHAMPLAIN

In summer 1814 Sir George Prevost led a British army from Canada south into New York. He halted outside Plattsburgh, waiting to be joined by a naval force under Commodore George Downie. The British naval squadron appeared off Plattsburgh on the morning of September 11, borne up the lake by a light northwesterly breeze. It was faced by a roughly comparable force of American vessels commanded by Master Commandant Thomas Macdonough. Macdonough had his four main ships—his flagship *Saratoga*, the brig *Eagle*, the schooner *Ticonderoga,* and the sloop *Preble*—anchored in a line across Cumberland Bay. They lay between a shoal and a headland, with gunboats in support. Downie advanced to attack aboard the newly built 39-gun frigate *Confiance*, the most powerful ship in the battle. With him were the brig *Linnet* and two sloops, the *Chub* and the *Finch*, plus a dozen gunboats.

Saratoga and *Ticonderoga* were soon engaged in a ferocious exchange of broadsides in the center of the line. Macdonough was temporarily disabled twice, once when a splintered boom struck him briefly unconscious, and a second time when the head of a decapitated sailor knocked him across the deck. Downie, less fortunate, was killed when struck by a long gun that had been blown off its carriage.

DESPERATE STRUGGLE

Meanwhile, at the south end of the line, *Finch* was crippled by broadsides from *Ticonderoga* and went aground on Crab Island, but on the American side *Preble* took a drubbing from British gunboats and drifted out of the battle. On the other flank fighting was no less fierce. The sloop *Chub* drifted dismasted into the American lines and was boarded, but in an encounter between the two brigs, *Eagle* and *Linnet*, the American *Eagle* came off worse. After two hours' fighting the fire began to slacken. Too many guns had been put out of action and too many men were dead or wounded. *Saratoga* was in poor shape, being raked by *Linnet* as well as facing what were left of *Confiance's* guns. But Macdonough would not accept defeat and summoned a last effort to gain the initiative. His starboard batteries, facing the British, were wrecked, but his port guns remained unused and largely intact. By hauling on cables his anchored frigate was turned around so its port broadside was brought to bear upon the *Confiance*. The British desperately strove to turn their own frigate but the exhausted remnants of the crew could not get the ship around. At the mercy of *Saratoga's* guns, *Confiance* struck, followed shortly by the battered *Linnet*.

The aftermath of the slaughter was handled with ceremonious dignity, the British officers handing their swords to Macdonough only to have them returned as a gesture of respect. As a result of the battle, Prevost abandoned his invasion of New York and the Americans were able to resist British claims to Lake Champlain and the Great Lakes in the peace negotiations.



WAR OF 1812

BATTLE OF LAKE CHAMPLAIN

Date	September 11, 1814
Location	Cumberland Bay, Plattsburgh
Result	United States victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES	BRITAIN

COMMANDERS

Thomas Macdonough	George Downie

FORCES

Ships: 1 frigate, 1 brig, 1 schooner, 1 sloop, 10 gunboats	**Ships:** 1 frigate, 1 brig, 2 sloops, 12 gunboats

LOSSES

Men: 52 killed, 58 wounded **Ships:** none	**Men:** 84 killed, 110 wounded **Ships:** 1 frigate, 1 brig, 2 sloops captured



Thomas Macdonough
This bronze medal, one of a series commemorating the War of 1812, features a bust of Thomas Macdonough, hero of the battle of Lake Champlain.



Battle of attrition
Commandant Macdonough's flagship *Saratoga* exchanges broadsides with HMS *Confiance* during fierce fighting on Lake Champlain. The battle was decided when *Saratoga* managed to bring her fresh portside guns against her exhausted opponent.